

COMMON OCTOPUS

Octopus vulgaris

Whether it is extricating a lobster from a lobster pot or hunting a scuttling crab, the common octopus is one of the most intelligent of all the invertebrates. This sea-living mollusc has excellent vision and eight grasping arms, or tentacles, which are also used for crawling. The octopus can change colour in an instant and squeeze through very narrow crevices. And its horny beak can bite into prey, whose scattered shell fragments frequently litter the sand around its lair. But in spite of its versatility, the common octopus is short-lived. Upon hatching, an infant octopus enters the oceanic plankton with half a million of its siblings, before descending to the seabed two months later. If it survives being eaten, it takes little more than a year to mature and spawn its own offspring before dying. The common octopus is widespread in tropical and warm temperate oceanic waters, and may consist of several similar species.

fleshy mantle encloses a cavity that contains vital organs, including gills for breathing

> INTELLIGENT MOLLUSC

An octopus is an agile predator with an advanced nervous system. Two-thirds of its neurons are located in its arms, which operate with a remarkable degree of independence from its brain. Experiments show that it also has considerable problem-solving intelligence, and excellent long- and short-term memory.



SIZE Tentacle span 1.5–3 m (5–10 ft)
HABITAT Rocky coastal waters
DISTRIBUTION Widespread in tropical and warm temperate waters
DIET Crustaceans, shelled molluscs

